Critical Reasoning Assumption Drill Pack

Argument Deconstruction Anatomy, The Negation Test Protocol & 10 Common CR Trap Traps

1. The 5-Step Critical Reasoning Assumption Methodology

An assumption is the unstated link that MUST be true for the argument's conclusion to hold. Follow this 5-step method.

Step in Method	Core Objective	Analytical Focus	Trap to Avoid
Step 1: Read the Question Stem	Identify that an assumption is requested	Look for words: "assumes", "assumption", "depends on", "relies on"	Do not confuse with Strengthen or Weaken prompts
Step 2: Deconstruct the Argument	Separate the Conclusion from the Premises	Conclusion is the claim; Premises are the facts/evidence	Never question the factual validity of stated premises
Step 3: Identify the Logical Gap	Spot the conceptual shift between premises and conclusion	Where does the author make an unproven cognitive leap?	Do not introduce outside general knowledge
Step 4: Pre-phrase the Assumption	Formulate in your own words what must connect the gap	Ask: "What must be true for this conclusion to survive?"	Do not look at answer choices before pre-phrasing
Step 5: Apply the Negation Test	Negate the shortlisted answer choice	If negating the choice destroys the conclusion, it is correct	Failing to negate accurately (e.g. all vs some)

Key Concept: A necessary assumption does not need to prove the conclusion; it merely protects it from collapsing.

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2. The Negation (Denial) Test Mechanics

The ultimate confirmation tool for assumption questions. Negate the statement: if the argument falls apart, the answer is correct.

Original Answer Statement	Proper Logical Negation	Impact if Argument Collapses	Verdict
"All executives prefer in-person meetings."	"Not all executives prefer in-person meetings."	If even one executive does not prefer it, does the plan fail?	Valid candidate for Negation Test
"Company revenue will increase next quarter."	"Company revenue will NOT increase next quarter."	If revenue stays flat or drops, does the investment argument fall apart?	Correct if conclusion is completely shattered
"No other factor contributed to the decline."	"At least one other factor contributed to the decline."	If another factor caused the decline, is the author's single cause invalidated?	Classic necessary assumption structure
"The new policy is more effective than the old one."	"The new policy is equally or less effective."	If it is not more effective, does the recommendation make sense?	Strong confirmation of assumption

Caution: Negating a statement means making it logically false, not asserting the polar opposite.

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3. Top 5 Attractive Traps in CR Assumption Questions

Identify and eliminate subtle traps that GMAC question writers insert to lure hasty test-takers.

- Trap 1: The "Strengthener" Trap. An answer choice that provides strong extra evidence but is NOT strictly necessary for the argument to survive.
- Trap 2: The "Out of Scope" Comparison. Introducing a comparison to another industry, city, or competitor that is not relevant to the author's specific logic.
- Trap 3: The "Too Extreme" Statement. Words like "always", "never", "solely", "completely" usually signal sufficient, not necessary, assumptions.
- Trap 4: The "Reverse Causality" Trap. Assuming that because A and B occur together, A must cause B, ignoring confounding third variables.
- Trap 5: The "Premise Restatement". Simply rephrasing a fact already stated in the passage without bridging the logical gap.